Trust the method, not just the name

Compare what sources disclose before deciding how much their reports deserve trust.

Suggested teaching time: 30 min | Preparation: about 5 min

Introductory | Secondary and adult learners | Individual writing, pairs, and class discussion

Prerequisites: None

Students will be able to

- Compare sources using disclosed methods and interests.
- Mark missing details instead of guessing them.
- Explain why a prestigious name or financial interest cannot settle a claim by itself.

Prepare and gather

- One student handout per learner, or display the activities and use paper.
- Pens or pencils; no student devices required.
- Keep the instructor guide and model answers separate from student materials.
- Read the three scenarios and their model answers.
- Print the student handout or display one activity at a time.
- Explain that all scenarios are invented and students should use only the supplied facts.

Teaching sequence

5 min	**Look for checkable details.** Learners compare the two bottle reports in the warm-up. Explain that an unsupported promise and a described test can be examined differently.
10 min	**Build a source comparison.** Pairs complete the app-source chart. Check that they distinguish participant recruitment from random assignment to groups.
8 min	**Discuss limits on trust.** Reveal the model answer. Discuss what methods and interests show, and why the missing results prevent a verdict about the app's benefit.
7 min	**Check a new pair of sources.** Learners complete the light-bulb exit ticket independently. Assess their method comparison, missing detail, and limited conclusion.

Timings are suggested starting points, not measured classroom completion times.

Warm-up / Two bottle reports

Student task and instructor answer

Explain these words as needed

Method: How information was gathered and checked.

Financial interest: A way someone could gain money from acceptance of a claim.

Comparison group: A group used to help judge what difference an action makes.

Scenario

Invented scenario: A bottle seller promises its bottle keeps water cold, with no test details. A consumer group publishes a timed test of that bottle and two rivals, using equal starting temperatures and room conditions. It does not disclose who funded the test. No temperature results are supplied.

Student output: Write the easier-to-check report, one reason, and one missing detail.

1. Choose the report that describes more of its testing method.

2. Name a stated detail that makes its comparison easier to inspect.

3. Name the missing funding detail and explain why you cannot yet decide which bottle performs best.

Student success check: Have you used the stated method rather than the organization's name alone?

Model answer

The consumer group's report is easier to check: it describes equal starting temperatures and room conditions. Its funding is not disclosed. We cannot decide which bottle performs best because no temperature results are supplied.

Why this meets the task: The answer identifies a useful disclosed method and a missing interest while keeping checkability separate from a performance verdict.

Main activity / Compare the sleep-app sources

Student task and instructor answer

Scenario

Invented scenario: An app seller says its product improves sleep, citing 12 testimonials with no recruitment details or sleep measure. A university team studies the same app: 200 adults are randomly assigned to app or no-app groups, sleep is measured identically, and the complete results and funding are disclosed. No result figures are supplied here; you are judging how checkable the sources are.

Student output: Make a two-row comparison chart and write two sentences evaluating how checkable the reports are.

1. Make a two-row chart, one row per source, with columns for participant selection, measurement, comparison group, and disclosed interests.
2. Write 'not supplied' wherever the scenario lacks a detail; do not invent it.
3. Write two sentences identifying which report is easier to check and why a seller's financial interest is a reason for scrutiny rather than automatic disproof.

Student success check: Did you compare reporting methods rather than trust the university's name or reject the seller's identity alone?

Model answer

Seller: selection not supplied; sleep measure not supplied; no comparison group described; sells the app. University: recruitment details not supplied, but random group assignment stated; common sleep measure; app/no-app comparison; funding disclosed. The university report is easier to inspect because it describes methods and a comparison. The seller has an incentive to promote the product, but that incentive alone does not prove its claim false.

Why this meets the task: It distinguishes known details from missing ones and treats incentives and methods as evidence to examine, not shortcuts to a verdict.

Exit ticket / Checking a light-bulb claim

Student task and instructor answer

Scenario

Invented scenario: A bulb maker says its bulbs use less electricity, citing three customers without test details. A local school reports testing its bulbs and a rival model for equal hours at the same light output, publishes all electricity readings, and says the maker donated both sets of bulbs. The readings themselves are not supplied here.

Student output: Compare the methods, identify a disclosed interest and a missing detail, and state what you can judge.

1. Identify which report gives more checkable testing details and name two of them.
2. State the school's disclosed support and one question you would ask about how bulbs were selected.
3. Explain why the school report is more checkable but these facts do not tell you which bulb uses less electricity.

Student success check: Have you treated donated equipment as something to examine, rather than automatic proof of a false claim?

Model answer

The school describes equal test hours and equal light output, and makes all readings available. It discloses that the maker donated both sets. I would ask how the particular bulbs were selected. The described test is easier to inspect, but without the readings here we cannot decide which uses less electricity; the donation alone does not settle whether the result is sound.

Why this meets the task: The answer uses reported methods, records the disclosed support, and names an actual missing detail without assuming dishonesty or inventing performance results.

Check understanding

Mark each criterion met or needs another attempt. Accept equivalent wording; assess the reasoning, not a memorized phrase.

- The report comparison cites actual method details rather than reputation alone.
- Known information is separated from missing details and disclosed interests.
- The conclusion concerns checkability and does not invent a performance result or infer dishonesty from an interest.

Discussion and adaptations

Use the supplied guidance to keep the lesson focused on its reasoning skill.

Discussion prompts

Does a university name guarantee a sound report?

Listen for: No. Examine what its report says about selection, measurement, comparisons, and disclosure. Prestige cannot replace those checks.

Does a seller's financial interest make its claim false?

Listen for: No. It gives a reason to scrutinize the claim and seek checks. A source with an interest may still supply accurate evidence.

Common confusions

Random assignment tells us how people were recruited. Recruitment selects who enters the study. Random assignment places those participants into groups. One does not supply the other.

Missing information proves a method was bad. Write "not supplied" and ask for it. A missing description is a limit on what we can assess.

A more checkable report guarantees a beneficial result. A transparent study might find no benefit or harm. Checkability is different from the direction of its results.

Adapt the lesson

More support: Draw the four-column chart first: participant selection, measurement, comparison group, disclosed interests. Read each source sentence and place only the stated information into its cells.

More challenge: Ask which app-source details remain missing after random assignment is stated. Expected examples: how the 200 adults were recruited or the exact sleep measure. Learners should request these details rather than invent them.

Next practice

https://xixteen.com/learners/?practice=source_reliability#workbench

Who Deserves Your Trust? Ask What They Can Predict:
https://xixteen.com/articles/prediction-markets-and-earned-trust/